PRESS INFORMATION BUREAU
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

PROGRAMMES FOR REMOVAL OF POVERTY TO BE ACCELERATED

PRIME MINISTER'S CALL FOR PEOPLE'S COOPERATION

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1894
August 15, 1972.

Addressing the nation on the 25th anniversary of Indian Independence from the Red Fort today, the Prime Minister, Shrimati Indira Gandhi, said that it was now necessary that programmes for the eradication of poverty should be accelerated and conditions created which were conducive to the strengthening of our society. She added that every citizen of India should make his or her contribution to the building up of a bright future of the country.

The Prime Minister said that though we became independent a quarter of a century ago, the kind of freedom that we wanted, we have not been able to attain so far. That freedom will be possible only when the mind of every man, woman and child is fully liberated, when he or she enjoys economic freedom and their minds are free from fear. Our independence cannot be considered complete so long as casteism is not eliminated from our society.

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Following is the free translation of the Prime Minister's speech:

Brothers and sisters! Twentyfive years ago our dear tricolour was unfurled for the first time at this spot. We a[redacted] you and the entire nation awoke into a new life that day. Yesterday night we paid our homage to those thousands and [redacted] of people whose service and sacrifice paved the way for our freedom. Different types of people participated in that freedom struggle, some believed in violence but most of the[redacted] became soldiers in our non-violent non-cooperation movement. It was the sacrifice of all those people which ignited the flame of freedom in this country and the biggest of powers [redacted] to yield before them. Those were really brave people who took out processions, held meetings, filled the jails, faced the bullets or were subjected to lathi blows. Most of them are no more with us. Some of them are present in our midst today. To those who are no more we pay our homage and those who are with us we thank them with a grateful heart. We al[redacted] remember those who pursued different path but still they al[redacted] fought for the freedom of the country with the same feelin[redacted] and courage and patriotism, whether they belonged to the [redacted] wal Regiment or whether they belonged to the Naval Ratin[redacted] Bombay. They were many people, how can I name them all [redacted] mention one I am likely to leave out many others. But [redacted] you know that some of the brave youngmen who were execute[redacted] imprisoned in this very Red Fort. We are grateful to al[redacted] brothers and sisters who belonged to the Indian Nationa[redacted] It is because of their sacrifice that today standing be[redacted] take this opportunity to express our gratitude to them.

A quarter of a century ago the Flag that was unfurled from here was not the end of a fight but it was a beginning, it was a beginning of a new fight of which both we and you are the soldiers. How can we make that fight for freedom a reality for our people, how can we give a new meaning to the word 'freedom' so that every household feels a new life. When we recall old things, at the same time we have before us men, the teeming poor people of India, for whom we have to fight, and for whose welfare we have to work hard. We have before us the children of the country with their shining eyes and beautiful faces for whom we have to explore new opportunities, there are before us the youngmen for whom we have to create new employment opportunities so that they may also serve the country in the same manner the others did and so that they may give new turning unitedly to the new story. During the last 25 years we have covered a long journey, a journey of comforts and hardships, difficulties and dangers but as you know, India of today is stronger than ever before, our democracy is stronger, our resolution is firmer and unity is also stronger than before.

If we look back then we should look forward also and we have also to see as to how can our pace be accelerated. How can we fulfil the pledges that we have taken. Many promises have been fulfilled but I regret to say that yet there are some people in our country who still question our achievements. There are some people who questioned the validity of the celebration of the Silver Jubilee of our Independence. This is a strange attitude and difficult to understand. Can't they see the progress that has taken place in India? Perhaps they do like it...

like it. There is a mighty force in India today and we should all try to strengthen it, and we have to add to this collective strength. I wish you all who are present here or the crores of people who are listening my voice on the radio or even those who are not listening that we should all stand united today. We should search our hearts and our heads and decide as to how we are to shape our dear India. During these years we have laid strong foundations to a country and you are fully aware of the progress that has taken place during the period. If we face some difficulty this year or if foodgrains could not reach a particular part of the country right in time that does not mean that there has been no progress. Many mistakes have been committed in the past perhaps some mistakes are being made even today and in spite of our best efforts we are liable to commit mistakes in future also but all these mistakes could not mitigate the successes and achievements that have been made. We have to observe ourselves that success has been achieved in many fields. Just as I said earlier that there has been drought in some parts of the country this year as it has been every year in one or the other part of the country. There have been floods too this year just as they occur in some parts of the country every year. But there is a great difference in what happened in the previous years and what is happening now. If you know the conditions prevailing in the rural areas you might be knowing that previously when there was a drought no external aid was rushed to the affected areas. But now if there is drought in some part of the country then immediately the city, the village the State Government and

other...

other people also make a united effort to overcome the difficulties created by the drought. It is our hope and it is our earnest effort that wherever there is any calamity in any part of the country we should always make a united endeavour to eradicate its ill affects . We cannot stop these calamities. We cannot prevent these vagaries of the na but we can always face them unitedly. Gradually this capacit of ours to work and to help others increases.

Along with the external aid I can also say that the individual is also helping himself more and more. Formerly if there was a calamity anywhere in India the people thought that they were helpless and they could do nothing to overcom it but now that voice of helplessness is less and less audib Gradually, the self-confidence of the people is increasing a every individual believes that he can do something, that he can play a vital role in changing his own life and overcomin the crisis. This actually is the greatest strength of a country. As you know there has been great progress in the field of agriculture. So also an industrial revolution has made great strides forward. Twenty-five years ago when became free our condition was really pitiable and our hearts were full of anxiety . We were faced with so many big problem that it was really difficult to find their solutions. You are aware of the fact that there were many people who thought tha though India has got freedom, she would not be able to preserve it. We were such a vast country and we had so many problems but you might have noticed that gradually all the critical and complex problems were solved one by one. So in this way there has been great progress in the industrial field also. The number of factories has increased the production...

the production of electricity has increased, so also the steel, big machines which were formerly imported from abroad are being manufactured by us now. Not only that even those machines which are used for manufacture of machines are also being made by us. It is true that all that we are producing, machines and other things, are not adequate for us. The more things are produced, the more electricity is produced the greater is the demand for it. The far greater is the increase in our population. So in this way we are always faced with the problem of how to meet the increasing demand. We know that most of the demands have not been met today. But this is no justification to believe that there has been no progress. This is not true. And this is not the correct way to look at the progress made nor to give a fillip to it because this is a way of despair. It is not a way of hope and courage. And those who say that there has been no progress in the country they do not correctly understand the people of India. Such people do not want to utilise the power of the people. They do not want to profit from the labour of the people.

So these...

So these are the tasks we have accomplished. You know that our country has been invaded five times and this is the occasion when on behalf of the Government, the people of India and on my own behalf I went to thank our brave Army, Navy and the Air Force for their heroic and courageous deeds. These brave soldiers protected the freedom of the country. They protected the frontiers of this country and therefore our hearts go out in sympathy for their families. I confidentally believe that the freed-- of India will always be safe in their hands, because these soldiers of the Army, Navy and the Air Force are the sons of India, they and their families have to bear the same stresses and strains which you and I face. The Indian Army, the Indian Police as well as all the sections of our society have to make a united effort to uplift this country. We fully realise that, however strong and brave the army of a nation may be, the real strength of a nation does not depend upon the strength of its army alone. The real strength of a nation depends on its progress, on its ideology, on the unity of its people, on the readiness of its people to make sacrifices. In the world of today, the problem is not whether we march forward or not , the question is not whether we work hard or rest, the real problem is that there is always tension in the world. And the real question is whether

we want...

we want to entangle ourselves in any dispute. Do we want to entangle ourselves in personal feuds, in petty matters or whether we want to fritter away the energies of the people and those of the government by entangling ourselves in useless agitations and quarrels or whether we want to look into our future and decide to make a bright future for ourselves. The real question is the type of people that we want to make, the opportunities that we want to give to our youngmen and children.

Today is different from yesterday and this difference is exemplified by the restlessness in the minds of the youngmen and others. This restlessness in the minds of Indian youngmen is not peculiar to India alone. This is prevailing in other countries also. What is the cause of this? May be in India this restlessness is because of unemployment, may be it is because of poverty but why is this restlessness in the minds of youngmen in other countries where there is no unemployment and where there is no poverty. To my mind the restlessness is there because we are emerging from one age and entering into another. You know when such a great transformation takes place it is bound to result in some restlessness, sorrow and suffering. We cannot remain stuck to the old world nor can we wish that there should be no change but we want to play our part in this change. These changes are of various kinds. There is poverty in India

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and it is necessary that we should implement programmes for eradication of poverty with greater force and speed and we should create conditions conducive to these changes. Droughts or floods, they are the calamities and we have no control over them. They will come as they must but our society should be stronger to face them. We have done a lot of things but we have to do much more still. If there is unemployment we have to enforce programmes to remove it as soon as possible. I wanted to tell you about all these programmes at the moment but for want of sufficient time it is not possible for me to go into details but these programmes have been explained in the Parliament and placed before the people at other forums. Some of them have already been undertaken and some of them are still to be taken up. Some of these programmes are intended for dealing with the immediate conditions and some of them have to deal with future conditions. After completing these programmes one by one we are marching forward step by step on our long journey but if we look at these problems only then we would not be able to make better future for ourselves. Whatever is to come will come and we will face it. This is not enough for India which has had a glorious history to wait for the future in a passive manner. We have to shape this future ourselves. We want that every Indian should have a hand in shaping her destiny. We are free for the last 25 years,

but as...

but as I said earlier the kind of independence that we want we have not been able to attain. We will have real freedom only when the mind of every individual, woman and child is fully liberated, when he or she enjoys economic freedom, social freedom and when his or her mind is free from fear. We want to build this sort of society in India. In fact we have to build this kind of world society. Today we cannot say we do not care what happens in the world, or that we Indians have nothing to do with it. We do not want any part of this world small or big. We do not want any part of this world small or big. We do not covet anybody's territory. We do not want to interfere in any nation's affairs. A nation can have any type of government it wants and pursue the path it likes, that is mainly its own concern. But we can only show by our example what is the correct way. We feel that in the last few days or months we have shown something. I have just referred to five invasions on India. You all know that the last attack was made last year and as a result of bravery, unity and prudence shown by our army and the people, India achieved a great and real success. You and I know that this was the success of a way of thinking, of an ideology and the world could see what India could achieve through its democracy. Whether it is an economic policy or a social policy, it has given strength to India, it has increased the unity of India and it has also created a new enthusiasm in the people of India so that they may be able to face any difficulty or take any risk.

any risk. We have thus not made an attack on anybody, nor have we tried to pressurise anybody. Others have tried to pressuri us. You and I know that gone are the days when we could be pressurised. We have shown the way to the world and I feel tha though some may criticise us yet the world at large has been influenced by our success. In future also we should not be blown off by the winds nor swayed by the currents but with eyes open we should make our own way intelligently. As you know this is not a readymade way. We have to make it step by step an therefore it is possible we may commit mistakes or w ay sometimes grow complacent and which may perhaps add to the suffering. Like the individual's character the nation's charac- ter is built on laborious efforts, the way of its thinking and not on resting or sitting idle. Those who lead a life of ease may be happy. They may be having palatial bungalows, lucrative jobs but they do not have the character. The real strength of the people is their character. The man who can work hard is the man of character. We do not want a nation which loves ease and comforts. If we say that we are fighting an economic struggle it does not mean that we want a life where people would be sitting idle but we want an order of life where one would earn his belly-full with hard labour, where one would have a roof over his head by working hard and where we would work laboriously for creating new and better opportunities for our children, for a life where we would all work hard unitedly. I feel that India's freedom will be complete only when we would be able to provide such opportunities to our people. I also feel that Indian independence would not be complete so long as we do not completely eliminate casteism from our society.

It would...

It would not be complete as long as anybody considers him low or others think him low. We are all human beings we are all Indians. We are all a different people, citizens of India, citizens of independent India, an ancient country which gave to the world a unique culture and high ideals. Now we have to show to the world that we have realised the values of that culture which is not a thing written in the books or in couplets but that culture should reflect itself in the heart and mind of every Indian citizen whatever may be his religion. There are many religions in India. When everybody follows his religion truthfully and sincerely India would become strong. No religion teaches that the other is bad or that the followers of one religion should fight or suppress those of the other. This has been the tradition of India. We have to see how can we spread this Indian tradition to the mankind and how can we invigorate this old tradition of ours and give it a new dignity. So the task that we face today is to be done today is not to be done tomorrow. We have to see what would be the face of India and that of the world a hundred years hence and I want your cooperation in the shaping of it. I have already welcomed our old revolutionary freedom fighters and others who are present here. We want inspiration from them. We want their blessings not for our personal selves but for this great country. I give my good wishes to the young generation of India. I want each and all of them to feel that he is a soldier of India and they have to see that how best they can build up a beautiful, a clean, a prosperous and a shining India whether they have to sacrifice themselves or whether

or whether they have to shed their blood and undergo some other suffering for it. The sovereignty, the strength, the unity of India is in your hands. Every Indian is a symbol. Though we are happy to find that some of our engineers have made great progress, that they are engaged in discovering the mysteries of atomic energy and that we know something about the atomic energy and develop it for the welfare of the people but we will be really happy only when every Indian know these things and considers himself the custodian of the honour and security of India not only against external aggressions but also against the evils of society.

I cannot tell you the way which can take India forward in the quickest possible manner. I do not know this way yet I do feel that there is some urge which is struggling restlessly to be released and this urge is pervading the entire mankind. This urge is the real strength of the human race out of which will emerge an absolutely new way and this could be a way not of fight and feud but a beautiful new way which will unite the people of the world which will ensure their mutual cooperation and help and which will help them unite in a single world family. We have to take a pledge today to attain this objective.

Poverty is to be eradicated not merely the economic poverty but also the poverty of ideology. We have to introduce a new ideology. The youngmen of today may sometimes commit mistakes. They may sometimes go astray but I am confident that they are a source of strength. Whatever strength and knowledge that we have should be utilised for making India strong and united. We should release this force and we should use it in showing a new way to the entire mankind.

You may...

You may like to know who is with us. India has many friends and we have always adopted a policy of strengthening our friendship with all the nations of the world. Recently as you know we have tried to come to an agreement with our neighbouring country. People ask me if I trust that country or not. My answer to them is that I trust only one country and that is India. We have to trust our people and our strength. No nation can march forward merely by trusting others. We want that there should be friendship and peace in this sub-continent and that we can march forward speedily but if you want to know who is with us then I will tell you, brothers, sisters and children, that courage, firmness and unity are our companions and if such are our companions then nobody can obstruct our way.

I offer you on this occasion my best wishes not for relaxing but for hard work and if we work hard together then we would be able to achieve much more by the next year and every year would be progressing forward.

Many children are present here. Some belong to the city, some have come from other cities. I welcome them all because the new world belongs to them and they will help making this new world and they would like to make it still a better world. Now I want to listen their beautiful voice. First I will raise the slogan "Jai Hind" thrice then the children will follow. Not only children but you all. Sometimes all of us should act as children, full of enthusiasm and if we learn to play together as children of all sections and communities, we would be learning a great lesson. Jai Hind.

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25/11/14.